great losses in their wake – the one of a friendship, the other of a friend.

~

Both campaigns left on the same day, 20 December 1585; and two months later, news arrived that Bhagwant Das and his officers, having marched into the bitter cold, across bad roads, through rain and snow, had negotiated a truce with the king of Kashmir, Yusuf Shah Chak. The shivering Mughal men – many of them Rajputs who would never have seen snow before – were in no state to offer battle, but Yusuf Shah, not having expected them to attempt an invasion at all through such difficult clime and country, offered to submit and return with them to Akbar's court. To this, Akbar offered no objection, but he insisted that his men march all the way through the valley and make it theirs before they returned. The officers were as reluctant to obey as the Kashmiris were unwilling to let them advance any further. Yusuf's son, Yaqub, met the Mughals with an army, and the two sides came to yet another settlement. Kashmir would offer Akbar the homage of khutba-u-sikka – the sermon to be read and coins to be minted in his name – along with revenue from its saffron, silk and game.

Again, word came to Akbar, in Punjab. Once, at the merest whisper of such reluctance to fight, Akbar would have leaped upon a horse and raced north to shame his men and shock his enemy. But now, as unhappily as his army had marched into the mountains, Akbar let them return. At the end of March 1586, on the last day of Nauroz, Bhagwant Das arrived in court, a submissive Yusuf Shah in tow – and Akbar put the Kashmiri king in jail.

It wasn't Akbar's usual policy to depose a conquered king who offered submission. The Rajput lords continued to rule their ancestral lands, as Sultan Daud might have in Bengal if he hadn't broken his truce with Munim Khan. 'Dignity is the maintenance of one's station' is one of Akbar's Happy Sayings.[12] Some years later, when Man Singh plundered an Oriya king called Ram Chand, the emperor 'who appreciates dignities' made Man Singh apologize. Why, then, would he show such disregard, both for Yusuf Shah's station and for the pride of his own amir and brother-in-law, Bhagwant Das, and the pledge he had made to the Kashmiri king?

Abul Fazl declares he did it on the bidding of his advisers, though it goes against the very grain of his narrative to have the divinely inspired Akbar